CAUGHT in the Scheme: A Multiple Case Study on the Experiences and Mindsets of Business Professionals Victimized by Ponzi INVESTMENTS

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ABSTRACT

This qualitative multiple case study investigated financially fraudulent acts and the behavioral patterns of investors. It focused on Ponzi schemes involving business professionals in the Soccskargen Region. By addressing a gap in the literature about lived experiences and cognitive processes, this study utilized maximum variation sampling to select the target cases. A total of five business people were selected in the region: an owner of a minimart, an online vendor, a dealer, a graduate of a Master in Business Administration, and a Certified Public Accountant, representing various professional backgrounds. In-depth interviews, triangulated with narratives of family members and close associates, were utilized to gather data. Results revealed three core theme categories: experiences (highlighting professional autonomy and systemic collapse), challenges (spanning insufficient literacy to emotional fallout), and lessons learned (prioritizing rigorous verification among other insights). The motives of the participants were quite similar, as they were characterized by the desire to get quick financial gains and professional overconfidence, but the emotional reactions to victimization were different. Despite the fact that most of the participants were found to have been in a state of great distress, two cases, the online seller and the accountant, were found to have been in a more measured state of psychological distress. These results indicate important behavioral vulnerabilities and have important implications on financial education, regulatory policy, and targeted interventions.

KEYWORDS: *Business management, Business professionals, Ponzi schemes, Multiple case studies, SOCCSKARGEN region*

Abbreviations
CPA - Certified Public Accountant
FOMO - Fear of Missing Out
MBA - Master's in Business Administration
PHP - Philippine Peso

SOCCSKARGEN - South Cotabato, Sultan Kudarat, Sarangani, and General Santos
UIC-REC - University of Immaculate Conception Research Ethics Committee

INTRODUCTION

Investment is one of the basic economic processes that involves the allocation of resources to assets with the anticipation of future returns (Ludeña, 2023; Remesh, 2025). Nevertheless, investors all over the world continue to be exposed to Ponzi schemes- fraudulent operations that use funds of new participants to pay alleged returns to earlier investors (Boyle and Peng, 2025; Peng and Boyle, 2024). These data visualizations show that financial sophistication does not provide protection against fraudulent schemes. This international trend highlights the need to study the processes by which fraud bypasses the financial protection measures. As argued by Bekoe et al. (2025) and Bongini et al. (2025), this global phenomenon underscores the need to examine the mechanisms by which fraud circumvents established financial safeguards.

The defraud victims in Ponzi schemes in Asia have been defrauded using the modern trends and referral bonuses (Samanta, 2025). In the same manner, the Philippines had experienced significant national effects because of fraudulent investment practices that promise unrealistically high returns (Innovations for Poverty Action, 2023a, 2023b; Morato, 2026). The Kapa Community Ministry and Rigen Marketing are informal investment communities that specifically targeted business professionals in the area through referral-based recruitment strategies (Cuadra, 2025; Ponteres et al., 2025). These illustrations highlight some of the most severe institutional failures and financial illiteracy, even among the most financially savvy victims.

Existing studies suggest that cognitive biases and persuasive recruitment tactics can affect professional victims and distort their financial decision-making (Hidajat et al., 2021; Ibrushi et al., 2026). It has been found that trust and reputation can be strategically employed to give a false sense of invincibility to financially literate individuals (Ahmad, 2025; Rauf et al., 2025). This research fills a significant gap in the literature on lived experiences and cognitive processes of financially sophisticated victims of fraud in the SOCCSKSARGEN Region.

Theoretical Lens

The theoretical framework used in this investigation was a multi-dimensional theory that consists of three complementary theories. At its core, the Rational Choice Theory (Becker, 1968) is based on the premise that people make decisions by systematically weighing costs against the expected rewards- a theory that is especially relevant in explaining how professionals evaluate investment opportunities. This framework is complemented by the Fraud Triangle Theory (Cressey, 1953), which conceptualizes financial fraud as the meeting of three factors: pressure (motivation to commit or participate in fraud), opportunity (circumstances that enable fraudulent behavior), and rationalization (cognitive justification of unethical actions). Also, the Behavioral Finance Theory (Kahneman and Tversky, 1979) was used to highlight the impact of psychological and cognitive biases, such as overconfidence bias, affect heuristic, and confirmation bias, on financial planning and risk assessment (Bianchi, 2023; Lusardi and Streeter, 2023). This theoretical prism, combined with each other, made it possible to consider the vulnerability of rational economic actors to systematic fraud despite professional training and financial literacy.

METHODS

The research utilized a complicated phenomenon: Ponzi scheme victimization in business professionals, and employed a qualitative multiple case study design (Yin, 2018). The qualitative research methodology was chosen since it enables the exploration of lived experiences, perceptions, and meaning-making processes without quantifying them numerically (Collins et al., 2024; Younas et al., 2023). Bingham (2023) argues that the multiple case study method allows analyzing cross-case patterns and retaining the contextual richness of individual experiences.

To sample five business professionals in the SOCCSKSARGEN Region who had been victimized by Ponzi schemes, maximum variation sampling was used (Nyimbili & Nyimbili, 2024). This sampling plan provided diversity across professional backgrounds, educational attainment, geographic location, and scheme involvement. The participants were: (1) Mrs. Minimart Owner (39 years old, female, BS Commerce, Midsayap, North Cotabato, lost PHP 1,000,000 to KAPA Community Ministry), (2) Mr. Online Seller (40 years old, male, BS Financial Management, General Santos City, North Cotabato, lost PHP 500,000 to Rigen Marketing), (3) Mrs. Dealer (26 years old, female, BS Education, Kidapawan City, North Cotabato, lost PHP 1,000,000 to Nermie Marketing), (4) Mr. Mba Graduate (39 years old, male, CPA and MBA, Columbio, Sultan Kudarat, lost PHP 2,500,000 to ALMAMICO), and (5) Mr. Accountant (39 years old, male, CPA and MBA, Columbio, Sultan Kudarat, lost PHP 2,500,000 to

ALMAMICO). Pseudonyms were used to ensure the confidentiality of the participants.

It was collected between January and March 2026 through in-depth semi-structured interviews with the main participants, which will be triangulated with additional interviews with family members and close associates (Meydan & Akkaş, 2024). Interview sessions ranged from 60 to 90 minutes and were digitally recorded using encrypted recording devices. Field notes were used to record non-verbal communication, contextual observations, and initial analytical observations. Interview protocols examined the participants' pre-investment backgrounds, decision-making processes, experiences with the schemes, post-collapse effects, and reflective learning.

Reliability was determined using a variety of standards. Credibility was achieved through long-term interaction with participants and methodological triangulation across various data sources (Meydan & Akkaş, 2024). Transferability was improved by the use of thick description, which provides enough contextual information for the reader to determine its applicability to other settings. Reliability was ensured by having detailed audit trails that record all analytical choices. Kullman and Chudyk (2025), Slettebjo (2021), and Saime et al. (2025) emphasize that confirmability is effectively achieved through reflexive journaling and member checking, where participants are empowered to review and validate interpretations of their narratives.

Ethical Statement

This study was submitted to the Research Ethics Committee of the University of the Immaculate Conception with a protocol code of GS-ER-01-26-0464. Upon careful consideration, the study was deemed ethically sound and received ethical clearance on February 18, 2026. All the procedures were carried out in strict compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012 (Republic Act 10173) and international ethical standards of human subjects research. All participants were informed and gave their consent after a thorough briefing on the purpose of the study, the procedures, risks, and potential benefits. Pseudonyms were used to ensure anonymity, and all the digital records were encrypted and stored safely. Also, member checking was adopted to make sure that the participants had agency over their narrative representations.

RESULTS

The thematic analysis resulted in three main categories that included the

experiences, challenges, and lessons learned by business professionals who were victims of Ponzi investment schemes. The cross-case analysis showed that there are universal patterns and case-specific variations in the five participants.

Table 1

Experiences of Business Professionals Before, During, and After Involvement in a Ponzi Investment Scheme

Theme	Description
Professional Autonomy	External validation-seeking was paradoxically decreased by independent business operation that cultivated financial decision-making confidence.
Social Influence	The universal recruitment gateway was trusted personal networks; social media increased reach.
Profit Motivation	The urge to get returns higher than the traditional investments led to calculated risk-taking, even among participants who are aware of fraud.
Initial Euphoria	The psychological reinforcement created by early payouts superseding rational skepticism and forming cognitive commitment..
Active Promotion	In case A, C, and E, others were recruited, which entangled them ethically and caused them moral distress.
Strategic Reinvestment	Most intensive in Cases D and E, systematic reinvestment of returns postponed the recognition of indicators of collapse.
Systematic Collapse	Cases A, D and E recognized collapse only when formal shutdowns occurred; Cases B and C disengaged earlier.
Emotional Fallout	Cases A, C, and D had severe distress; Cases B

	and E were more resilient.

Eight key themes were identified to explain the experiences of the participants in the temporal phases: professional autonomy, social influence, profit motivation, initial euphoria, active promotion, strategic reinvestment, systematic collapse, and emotional fallout. The five participants were their own business people before joining the schemes and they acquired professional identities that were characterized by financial decision-making authority. The universal access point to scheme participation was social networks, and participants were recruited using trusted personal relationships who used existing relationships to build credibility (Cuadra, 2025; Bongini et al., 2025). The rational skepticism was overruled by the cognitive commitment that was produced by the early payout experiences and contradictory evidence was opposed. Balcombe (2025) and Homer et al. (2023) note that the psychological outcomes were different; Cases A, C, and D showed severe emotional distress, including insomnia, anxiety, and depression, whereas Cases B and E demonstrated more moderate responses.

Table 2
Challenges Encountered by Business Professionals Before, During, and After Involvement in a Ponzi Investment Scheme

Theme	Description
Insufficient Literacy	The formal business education failed to provide knowledge specific to fraud; overconfidence concealed critical knowledge gaps.
Social Pressure	The uninformed decision-making was accelerated by FOMO due to the observation of the apparent success of peers.
Financial Risk	The amount of investment made went beyond the initial risk tolerance; Cases D and E invested large amounts of their assets.

Moral Responsibility	The participants that recruited others felt deeply guilty even beyond the personal financial loss.
Emotional Distress	Universal were chronic stress, anxiety, depressive symptoms, and relationship strain; Case A had suicidal ideation.
Reputational Damage	The victim-promoter duality resulted in permanent reputational damage to the victim and the promoter.
Financial Disruption	Planned expansions were canceled, assets were liquidated; Cases A and D took a long time to stabilize.

Seven themes of challenges were identified: lack of literacy, social pressure, financial risk, moral responsibility, emotional distress, reputational damage, and financial disruption. Although the participants have professional backgrounds and formal business education, none of them possesses fraud-specific knowledge or due diligence frameworks (Guiamsay & Rabago, 2025; Bianchi, 2023). This loophole was covered by overconfidence in overall financial competence. Endorsed networks stimulated uninformed decision-making, while FOMO overcame prudent decision-making (Samanta, 2025; Epelbaum, 2025). The victim-promoter duality resulted in long-term reputational damage, with Case D having the most significant professional and social impact.

Table 3

Lessons Learned by Business Professionals from Their Experiences with Ponzi Investment Scheme

Theme	Description
Rejecting Easy-Money Myths	Basic reconceptualization to evidence-based investment strategies; cognitive change to analytic reasoning as opposed to heuristic reasoning.
Prioritizing Rigorous	The dedication to the research of regulatory

Verification	compliance, registration, financial audits, and independent reviews.
Investing Within Secure Limits	Setting up individual investment boundaries in accordance with risk tolerance and financial ability.
Questioning Rapid Returns	Distrust of abnormally high or assured returns became a key protective heuristic.
Addressing Systemic Gaps	Identification of institutional and regulatory gaps; lobbying to increase regulation and fraud registries.
Upholding Ethical Standards	Compliance with transparency and reluctance to conduct any business without explicit records of its validity.

Six themes of the lesson were identified: rejection of easy-money myths, the importance of rigorous verification, investing within safe limits, questioning rapid returns, addressing systemic gaps, and maintaining ethical standards. The thing is that all participants have re-defined their investment philosophy and shunned their backs on impulsive decision-making and evidence-based approaches. Verification was found to be the most important protective behavior and the participants were ready to investigate regulatory compliance and independent reviews before they could invest in the future. Yusuf (2025) and the UNODC (2025) note that one of the reasons why the government should be more vigilant and offer more accessible financial education programs is the awareness of institutional and regulatory shortcomings.

Table 4

Similarities and Differences of the Experiences, Challenges, and Lessons Learned by Business Professionals Involved in a Ponzi Investment Scheme

Dimension	Similarities	Differences
Experiences	The universal aspects that	The entry mode of social

	were present in all five cases were professional autonomy, profit motivation, and social trust destruction.	influence was different: Cases A and C through word-of-mouth; Cases B, D, and E through digital platforms. The emotional severity was between acute crisis (A, C, D) and measured coping (B, E).
Challenges	All participants did not have any knowledge specific to fraud despite professional training; financial disruption was universal.	The intensity of moral burden was associated with promotional involvement; Cases A, C, and E had the highest intensity of moral burden. The severity of reputational damage depended on the position of community leadership.
Lessons Learned	A basic cognitive change was that all participants developed a verify first attitude after victimization.	The priorities of the lesson varied: some were concerned with the clarity of the law and the reform of the regulations; others were preoccupied with the personal verification procedure and the ethical code.
Overall Pattern	Excessive use of personal judgment as opposed to systematic due diligence was universal.	The recovery patterns and the degree of resilience depended on the presence of promotional activity and prior financial security.

The cross-case analysis showed that all five participants had professional autonomy, a profit motive, and an overreliance on intuitive judgment rather than on systematic due diligence. The destruction of social trust was universal and

radically altered participants' interpersonal relationships and community participation. There were differences in social influence entry mechanisms, severity of emotional response, intensity of moral burden, and prioritization of lessons, which reflected the diversity of professional backgrounds and scheme contexts represented in the sample.

DISCUSSION

The results shed light on the important crossroads between professional identity, cognitive biases, and vulnerability to fraud. This discussion combines empirical findings with the theoretical framework and the existing literature to explain how business professionals become victimized despite financial training, and draws implications to education, policy, and professional practice.

Professional Autonomy, Overconfidence, and Rational Choice Theory

Professional autonomy, which is typically considered an asset, in fact, predisposed one more to overconfidence bias. The success of the participants in business resulted in self-confidence in financial judgment, which reduced the perceived need to consult external advice or systematic verification (Ahmad, 2025; Ibrushi et al., 2026). This observation is consistent with the body of research in behavioral finance showing that expertise in one area can lead to false confidence in related but distinct areas (Huber et al., 2025).Notably, these findings confirm the Rational Choice Theory (Becker, 1968), with a significant qualification: the participants did go through a cost-benefit analysis, but this analysis was systematically distorted by false information, cognitive biases, and emotional factors. The results, therefore, confirm the models of bounded rationality where decision-makers strive to conduct a rational analysis under the conditions of cognitive and informational limitations- a fact that formal financial education must explicitly address. Bianchi (2023) and Guiamsay and Rabago (2025) believe that in the case of educational institutions, business courses must include fraud-specific topics, including Ponzi scheme mechanisms, red flags, and verification procedures. This form of integration is a significant move in the bigger process of changing the focus of professional autonomy to the practical ability to overcome cognitive distortions.

Social Influence, Network-Based Recruitment, and the Fraud Triangle

The main recruitment tool was social influence, and credibility to participate in the scheme was based on trusted relationships (Bongini et al., 2025; Rafik et al., 2023). A more sophisticated type of fraud that does not arouse rational

suspicion by appealing to emotional trust is the exploitation of social capital. These findings are a strong support of the Fraud Triangle Theory (Cressey, 1953) since it identifies the three components of the theory: pressure in the form of profit motivation and social pressure; opportunity created by professional autonomy and inadequate regulatory control; and rationalization through initial euphoria, social proof, and active promotion justifies continued involvement. The recommendations, as proposed by UNODC (2025) and Yusuf (2025) to regulatory agencies, are that accessible fraud registries, enhanced enforcement of investment regulations, and publicity campaigns targeting professional communities should be established.

Cognitive Biases, Behavioral Finance, and Profit Motivation

Profit motivation was motivated by cognitive and emotional biases instead of rational financial analysis (Hidajat et al., 2021; Prabowo, 2023). The affect heuristic, in which emotional reactions dominate over rational thought, was reflected in the attraction of high-return promises by participants. Confirmation bias made participants to selectively attend to information that was favorable to scheme legitimacy and ignore warning signals. These findings provide a solid support of Behavioral Finance Theory (Kahneman and Tversky, 1979) through the discovery of the affect heuristic, overconfidence bias, confirmation bias, and the social proof heuristic, which work in a synergistic manner to override technical financial knowledge (Lusardi and Streeter, 2023; Rauf et al., 2025). These findings in the case of professional organizations justify mandatory continuing education programs, with an emphasis that professional expertise does not offer immunity against victimization by fraud.

Active Promotion, Ethical Entrapment, and Moral Injury

The vigorous encouragement resulted in two types of victimization: financial loss and moral injury. The recruiters of other participants were exposed to complex psychological trauma that entailed personal loss, guilt, and social responsibility (Egiyi & Chindengwike, 2023; Cross et al., 2022). This observation demonstrates that Ponzi schemes make victims unwitting accomplices, who drag the implications of the scheme out of the financial sector. The fact that the severity of emotional reactions depends on the involvement in promotions and past financial stability demonstrates that the psychological impact is moderated by the participation in promotions and previous financial stability (Balcombe, 2025; Homer et al., 2023). According to Button et al. (2024) and Freeman (2024), financial counseling services should be developed on the basis of trauma-informed support protocols that take into account both the psychological and

moral aspects of victimization in fraud cases, and in the case of victim-promoters with compound guilt, in particular.

Systematic Collapse, Financial Disruption, and Systemic Implications

The mathematical inevitability of failure of Ponzi schemes, regardless of how the participants leave them, is confirmed by the universal experience of systematic collapse (Boyle and Peng, 2025; Peng and Boyle, 2024). The financial crisis required the complete reorganization of the business as the participants canceled the expansion plans, liquidated the assets, and fundamentally changed the business strategies (Homer et al., 2023; Bar-Lev, 2022). The economic effects were not only the loss of direct investment but also the opportunity costs, business stagnation and long term financial instability. These results underscore the systemic economic impacts of victimization by fraudulent schemes at both the individual and community levels, and highlight the futility of trying to time exit from fraudulent schemes (Bekoe et al., 2025). Integrated financial vigilance programs of Region XII, which combine education, regulatory oversight, and community-based fraud monitoring, may be effective in addressing the systemic gaps identified by participants.

Lessons Learned, Behavioral Transformation, and Educational Implications

The lessons learned are the basic cognitive and behavioral changes. Post-traumatic growth and adaptive learning are evidenced by the rejection of easy-money myths, the focus on rigorous verification, and adherence to ethical standards. But these lessons were learned at a very high personal cost, which explains why preventive education is preferable to experiential learning through victimization (Mahamas & Ladra, 2025; Onoh, 2025). The shift to a vigilant investor, which all five participants achieved through painful experience, must be facilitated by proactive, case-based pedagogy that uses real victimization stories to enhance emotional engagement and retention (Bianchi, 2023; Guiamsay & Rabago, 2025). Cultures of critical thinking and institutional safeguards are needed to safeguard business professionals in Region XII and beyond.

CONCLUSION

This paper will show that professional knowledge fails to safeguard individuals against victimization by Ponzi schemes. The overconfidence, social influence, and profit motivation combine to form a behavioral vulnerability paradox where professional competence is a risk factor and not a

protective factor. The process of making investment decisions is basically a human process that is subject to the influence of emotion, social environment, and cognitive bias that can override the technical knowledge, a fact that is confirmed in all three theoretical lenses applied in this study. Financial literacy must be redefined in the framework of behavioral finance models that explicitly take into account psychological vulnerabilities and capabilities specific to fraud. The culture of critical thinking, institutional protection and specific programs of fraud prevention is required to protect business professionals in Region XII and further. The research will contribute to the limited literature on financially sophisticated victims of fraud and will have a practical implication on educators, regulators, and professional bodies that are dedicated to preventing fraud and promoting financial resilience.

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Follow APA Format, arrange references alphabetically, and use hanging indentations.

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for having presented a study titled
CAUGHT IN THE SCHEME: A MULTIPLE CASE STUDY ON THE EXPERIENCES AND MINDSETS OF BUSINESS PROFESSIONALS VICTIMIZED BY PONZI INVESTMENTS
during the UIC Graduate School International Research Forum 2026 with the theme, "Frontiers of Research: Navigating Emerging Challenges and Opportunities in a Rapidly Changing World", at the University of the Immaculate Conception, Bonifacio Campus, Bonifacio St., Davao City
Given this 9th day of May in the year of our Lord 2026.
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Dean, Graduate School

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May 16, 2026

Lovella Faith B. Diez
Accounting and Finance Head
Kidapawan Doctors' College Inc.

Dear **Ms. Diez,**

Praised be Jesus and Mary!

We are delighted to inform you that your scientific article, **CAUGHT in the Scheme: A Multiple Case Study on the Experiences and Mindsets of Business Professionals Victimized by Ponzi INVESTMENTS ,** has been accepted for publication in International Journal of Education Research for Higher Learning (IJERHL). Congratulations on your accomplishment!

Our editorial team and reviewers have reviewed your work, and we believe it will make a valuable contribution to the scientific community. The comments and suggestions of the peer reviewers were minor, and these have been integrated into the article by the editorial staff.

Thank you for choosing **UIC** as the venue for disseminating your research findings. We look forward to publishing your work and sharing it with the scientific community.

Very truly yours,

Dr. Emma V. Sagarino
Director of Research

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